

sa

ISSUE 1 2020

Homeschooling

LIVING & LEARNING – TOGETHER

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Choosing the right
curriculum and
programme

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knowledge nature
teaches children

Raising happy
readers – the
rewards of reading

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Be inspired by your very own printable poster



Ed's note

Hello, and welcome to our first issue of *SA Homeschooling*.

How our world has changed in the last year. Whereas homeschooling in South Africa was once considered 'fringe' it is rapidly becoming part of our new normal. Parents were suddenly obliged to aid their children's learning at home, with many now choosing to permanently remove their children from traditional schools. Homes have been reorganised to create workspaces, while parents frantically search for the best system or curriculum to support their children's education. For them, it's a whole new – and often frightening – world.

Of course, many other families are old hands at homeschooling, having decided long ago that 'school' wasn't the best environment for their children to grow academically, emotionally and socially.

SAH is here for all of you; to share information, trends and stories that will guide you on your journey, and to let you know that you're not alone.

Happy reading, happy learning!

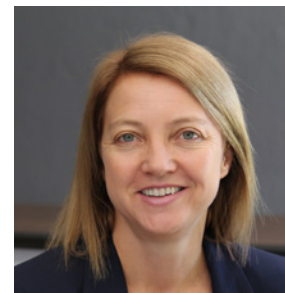
Shelagh

Editor, *SAH*

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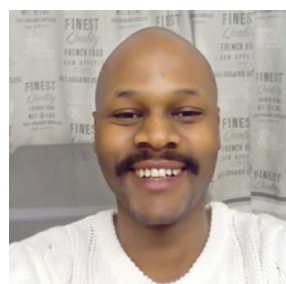
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www.linkedin.com/company/cambrilearn/ | www.youtube.com/CambriLearn

KATE CURTIS

Passionate about nature, education, permaculture, food gardens and forests. I co-founded Soil*Sun*Soul, an educational organisation that runs international agro-ecological training. I also co-facilitated international youth programmes and sustainable food production workshops and now collaborate at a permaculture community on the Garden Route and teach at a local homeschool.



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If you're new to the idea of homeschooling – or have been thrown in the deep end by Covid-19 – it's hard to know what to consider when looking for a service provider for your child. Educator **Brett Garner** offers some pointers

Where to begin?

In Lewis Carroll's *Alice's Adventures in Wonderland*, the White Rabbit asks a question familiar to every homeschooling parent: 'Where shall I begin?' The uninitiated may respond much like the King of Hearts and be motivated by the same benevolence: "Begin at the beginning," the King said, very gravely, "and go on till you come to the end: then stop."



from those who know or those who don't, most begin their homeschooling journey feeling a little like Alice listening to the Queen of Hearts campaigning for the head of the Knave of Hearts: 'Sentence first – verdict afterwards!'

With respect to the queen and every benevolent advisor, no parent can afford to dive in, 'sentence first', only to discover that the verdict is that a chosen curriculum, programme or package doesn't work – for them or their child.

In my experience, the decision to homeschool must be preceded by the need to do so. For some, that need is curriculum-driven; a parent's ideology may clash with that of the state, say. For others, it's a more practical matter. A bricks-and-mortar school may be physically

inaccessible or closed because of the pandemic. Still others may feel that their child's particular physical, emotional or learning needs will be best met at home.

Whatever the need, I've found that the most successful homeschoolers are fully convinced of the validity of homeschooling as the best option for their child's needs at the time. Homeschooling isn't easy; it requires time, energy, focus and resources. If parents aren't confident that they're making

'The most successful homeschoolers are fully convinced of the validity of homeschooling as the best option.'

'Use these books,' they'll say, or 'subscribe to that online programme', 'buy lots of wall charts', 'go for anything non-toxic' and 'don't use food as a reward'. While there's sure to be value in most words of advice, whether



the best choice for their family, their efforts will be wasted.

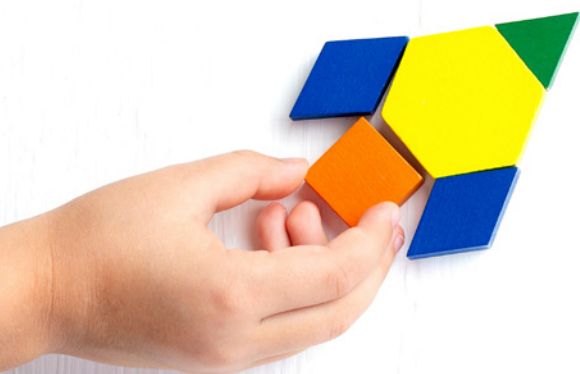
With the need identified, the next important step is finding support. This will come in many forms, most notably that of similarly persuaded homeschooling families. My advice is to find a 'clubhouse', a local network, and to meet regularly to share knowledge, laugh at yourselves and gain support when the going gets tough.

Additional support will come in the form of a curriculum, a physical teaching space, teaching resources such as books and charts (and non-toxic markers), online platforms, courses, the odd practical art or music class, and sport and social clubs.

Decisions, decisions . . .

Each of the above is worth a discussion on its own, which I will

'The world of learning is dynamic and best practice is constantly in flux.'



initiate in future issues of *SAH*, but to appreciate why I regard each as a support to homeschoolers, consider the following essentials when making your choice of service provider:

- Is the curriculum internationally recognised as academically sound and rigorous?
- Does the organisation offer readily available curriculum-aligned textbooks, workbooks, wall charts, websites, online courses, etc?

- Is the curriculum flexible enough in the lower grades to allow you, as parents, to meet your ideological ideals?
- Is the curriculum accommodating enough to cater for pupils with particular education needs?
- Is the service provider able to offer courses such as art or music that are aligned to the curriculum, or will you need to look elsewhere for the more practical subjects?
- Do they offer other support resources and 'add-ons', if needed?
- Will your child/children be working towards a qualification sought after by tertiary institutions and employers?
- Is the above point important to you and potentially important to your child?
- Is the system tried and tested and can you read reviews from other users?
- Can you afford it?

With the decision made and support in place, you could be forgiven for thinking that the job is done. It's not. The world of learning is dynamic and best practice is constantly in flux. Homeschoolers have to keep an eye not only on content delivery, but on content *and* delivery,

context, the law and their child's social, emotional, cognitive and physical needs. On top of that, there are the day-to-day demands of being a parent, or working, or simply trying to get on with life.

It's also vital that every homeschooler sets time aside to stay informed about the world of learning.

Once the why, what and how of homeschooling are all in place, the final step is to reflect on your decision. Motivations change. Children change. The world changes. A new school may appear on the homeschooler's doorstep, along with a cure for that debilitating Covid-19 pandemic.



"Begin at the beginning," the King said, very gravely, "and go till you come to the end: then stop."

- Lewis Carroll

Change is inevitable, so the cycle will repeat itself. Why do I want to homeschool? What will I use to homeschool? How well am I homeschooling? Do I want to keep on homeschooling?

Perhaps, when the nest is empty, the advice given to the White Rabbit will apply and you may consider it time to stop. Or not. But for now, to paraphrase the Cheshire cat (which told Alice that if you don't much care where you're going, then it doesn't matter which way you go), homeschoolers care very deeply where they're going – and have every reason to continue getting there. It's my wish that it's a joyful process for you and your family.



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Creating a learning space



LIGHTING

While LED lighting might seem counter-intuitive, the experts at www.warehouse-lighting.com believe it's the best option: 'LED stands out for a workspace for a few reasons. For one thing, it offers a clear and clean light, free of flickers, for a consistent and comfortable light source. It's also free of glares, which can help your eyes stay comfortable when working long hours.' LED lights are also more cost-effective in the long run.

COLOUR

www.shiftelearning.com recommends the blues. 'Blue is best used for learning situations which are challenging. Blue paper, blue ink or blue highlighting can be used to help improve reading comprehension too. Blue in general, it seems, is a relaxing and calming colour, but lighter shades will seem more "friendly", while darker ones seem a little more sombre.' But do take your child's preferred colours into account, as a sense of belonging is essential for relaxed learning.



SEATING

One of the advantages of a traditional classroom is that all the desks and chairs are specifically designed for child-sized bodies. So, while a dining table and chair might work for a teenager, younger children will battle to sit comfortably and are apt to become fidgety. Little feet need to reach the floor and little arms should be able to rest comfortably on the table or desktop. An ergonomically designed chair will cost more, but will be worth it.



Whether you live in an apartment with multi-purpose areas or a larger home with a dedicated homeschooling room, there are a few points to consider when creating the ideal learning environment for you and your child

WORK SURFACE

If you're short of space, consider attaching castors to the legs of a table so that you can move it around as needed. Trestle tables are also great, as they can be tucked away during holiday time. Just be sure to seal or paint the surface to make cleaning a breeze. As with seating, comfort is paramount, so make sure the work surface isn't too high or too low.



STORAGE

Unless you're cool with chaos, dedicated storage is a must, but it doesn't have to be expensive.

Upcycled kitchen cabinets or old office units can easily be repurposed and are designed for easy cleaning. Old shoe boxes or biscuit tins can be used for stationery and other bits and bobs, while those rectangular bins with clip-on lids are ideal for bigger items. Just remember to label them. And don't forget a bookcase or two.

THE FEEL

One of the (many) blissful things about homeschooling is that the workspace can be both familiar and welcoming (an observation rarely made about a traditional classroom). Don't be afraid to inject familiar objects, posters and artworks into your child's study environment. Even teddy-bears should be welcome.





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With the growth of homeschooling in South Africa, ROCA Kids – a proudly local company based in Cape Town – has focused on offering space-saving solutions to parents. The company initially launched with the Aidan desk, which became its best-seller, and hones in on functionality, space-saving and visual appeal. Roca Kids also offers a cost-effective wall-mounted option, the Pandora, as well as two corner desks, the Jess and the Abby, as part of its space-saving offering.

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T&Cs The winner will be contacted telephonically by SA Homeschooling Magazine and their name will be published in Issue 2. The prize must be taken up as awarded and cannot be transferred to any other person, sold or converted to cash. The competition is open to all residents of South Africa over 18 years of age, except employees of Isikhova Media or ROCA Kids Furniture & Decor. The prize includes free shipping to major centres.



IF MONDAY'S DON'T
EXCITE YOU.
THEN IT'S TIME TO
CHANGE YOUR
SCHOOL



What can a love of nature teach children about themselves and the world they live in? Author, alternative educator and permaculture practitioner **Kate Curtis** sows the seeds of understanding

The nature connection

I think of nature connection as the art of remembering. We live in a world of unprecedented species loss, environmental exploitation and destruction of habitat, social inequalities, climate crisis and injustices. I consider nature connection to be an antidote to disconnection and a return to belonging; an essential first step to healing our relationship with Earth, our only home.



Children who form a deep connection to nature are far less likely to cause environmental harm. As Joanna Macey and deep ecologist and environmental activist John Seed wrote in *Thinking Like a Mountain: Towards a Council of All Beings*: 'Unless we can identify with the ecosystem and think like a mountain, disaster is inevitable.'

Research has also shown that children and adults who spend more time outdoors have stronger

immune systems and greater mental health resilience. Studies have proven that contact with microbes in the soil makes us happier and healthier.

Connecting to our natural environment can take place in many ways. As South Africans, many of us have the privilege of being able to access wild spaces such as forests, mountains, undisturbed beaches, clear rivers and lakes. Simply spending time observing and

slowing down can lead to healing and, often, profound insights. Nature connection is answering the invitation to step out of our human-centred world view and begin to observe and learn from the greater world to which we belong.

However, connecting to nature doesn't have to happen in pristine environments; there are ways we can connect through simply slowing down and observing an element of nature, such as a tree or even a pot plant, with all five senses.

What about the city-dwellers?

If you're fortunate enough to have a garden, start there! It's amazing how much life can exist in a small

**'The world
doesn't belong to us.
Rather, we belong to
the world.'**



space. If you don't have access to a garden, try to find a place where you can walk or a park to visit. Start a nature journal, observing the clouds, the moon, the changing sunlight hours, weather patterns,

temperatures and the water cycle. I love the project of germinating a bean seed and watching it grow. Sunflowers in pots are also great. If you can connect with other families to share expenses and travel costs, arrange a regular visit to a local park, rockpools or forest. I suggest you plan some activities, but also allow children time for free play and self-discovery. Journal about these days out and ask questions like: 'What surprised you today? What sounds did you hear?'

There are also excellent nature documentaries online that can be used as themes for art projects or quizzes. I've found that linking biology and art is a powerful way of grounding the lesson and engages both sides of the brain for deeper understanding.

Nature infiltrates all

Deep ecologist Arne Næss wrote about the connection between deep experiences which lead to deep questioning, which – in turn – leads to a deep understanding and an inevitable desire to protect and deeply commit. Taking your children out into nature and encouraging



them to explore and enquire is a great way to promote learning.

Subjects like history and geography are profoundly interconnected; as human civilisations and societies have grown, they've had lasting impacts on the landscapes. Typically, they're related to from a human-centric viewpoint, but we're not the only inhabitants on our planet. One way of connecting nature to these lessons is by asking questions such as: 'How do you think the forest was affected by that war?' Older children can discuss or write an essay about the colonisation of a place from the viewpoint of an animal of the ecosystem living there at that time. Suddenly, the facts 'stick' because the story's richer.

Taking physical education outdoors offers opportunities that a gym hall doesn't. Set up a challenging nature obstacle course with your children

for limitless questions regarding science.

'Where does the air you breathe come from?' 'Why does your heart beat faster when you're running?' 'What makes leaves fall?' 'Why can't humans fly?'

Nature offers an introduction to scientific phenomena such as gravity, force, photosynthesis, the carbon cycle and more.

We can also connect to nature through stories, around a fire or candle, or looking up at the starry sky and imagining a world before technology and Google. How did ancient people explain the cycles of the moon? You

could encourage your child to record a moon diary or weather journal, or to plant a seed and follow its life-cycle from germination to

Image by 政徳 吉田 from Pixabay



flower and back to seed.

Connecting to nature is about studying life through the head, heart and hands – and, ultimately, realising that we, too, are a part of it. As

Albert Einstein said: 'Look deep into nature. Then you'll understand everything better.'

Tip: Always be sensitive to the learning style that best suits your child and try to offer diverse ways of approaching the same subject.



'Look deep into nature. Then you'll understand everything better.'



I wrote and published *The King and the Tree* some years ago, when I worked in Spain as a homeschool and language teacher. I often struggled to find the right reading material for younger children and was inspired to create a book that would invite deeper questioning and discovery through detailed water colour illustrations and the lesson the little king learns. I hope that, through the book, children and adults will learn that we're part of a beautiful, intelligent, interconnected ecosystem. Please contact me at: kate@greenhearted.net if you're keen to buy a copy.



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Send your letters to: shelagh@isikhova.co.za and you could win one of four CNA gift vouchers worth R500 each.

This issue's theme is 'Top Tips' – and what wonderful ideas you sent in!

All together

Create a space in a quiet place for your child. Set out a daily schedule and learning goals together and make it a family activity, going beyond the classroom by playing board games, exploring for insects, playing with sand and looking at flowers and plants.

Adeline



Place and time

My kids have been home-schooling since the lockdown and what I've learnt is that it's vital to have a timetable in place so that you give proper time slots to each subject. A dedicated workstation is also key to establishing a proper routine and mood.

Sandy



Real CNA fan!

My first tip is to read a story with your own added twist to set the little ones up for the next day. This lets your kids know (without them realising it) what tomorrow's lessons or playtime will be about. You'll notice their confidence the next day when they realise that they already know a little of what you're about to teach them.

At breakfast time, build a face or an adventure scene with fresh fruit and veggies, cheese and crackers or even boiled egg and bacon. The clay-cutter shapes at CNA work well for cutting bite-sized shapes out of sandwiches.

Add colour to the lesson (a great go-to are the Pritt foam letters and shapes at CNA) or make up a song as you teach your lesson.

File the kids' completed lessons in colourful pouches. Children like seeing their progress and knowing that their efforts are being kept safely. We like to use the CNA quality plastic document pouches.

Let your kids take ownership of learning. CNA has some of the best brain-stimulating activities for all ages, like finger face-painting, maze and puzzle books, trivia and board games.

Chantellé



Heading off challenges

Although home-schooling has a great many benefits, while managing both

my kids (one in Grade 9 and the other in Grade 3), I faced some challenges. So I made a room in my home available and turned it



into a classroom for my younger son, in particular. I also introduced a fun work schedule that included playtime, TV time, screen time and some rewards to help with educational motivation.

Both my kids enjoy soft music in the background when studying.

I use a sheet of white paper and sticky notes for projects and their respective deadlines.

The schedule includes free time for simply playing and we do some arts and crafts to stimulate their minds.

In these stressful times, I've included opportunities for my



boys to give back to others and do recycling in and around our community. It certainly innovates their thinking and they enjoy being part of change. It's also taught them to appreciate the smaller things in life.

Natasha



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Pearl of wisdom

Mrs South Africa finalist and mother of 10 (yes, 10!) Pearl Osa left the corporate life to homeschool her children. She shares her fascinating journey while offering some great tips and advice

It was the end of 2013 and I was fetching my children on the last day of the school year. I stopped to chat to one of the teachers and, as we conversed, I became aware of certain values that were fundamentally different from the values we held at home. It must have been the last straw, as I'd been confronted by a few of these conversations over the years. Mind you, this was a school supposedly founded on the same religious and values-based systems we held as a family. That was the reason we'd chosen the school in the first place!



But I now realised that what I was expecting from outside forces wasn't their responsibility. It was mine. And I was resolute about taking my responsibility back.

This is what I've learnt.

Before embarking on home-schooling, as with any other crucial life decision, it's best to ask yourself a few questions. For more practical individuals, the first one is: 'Do I have the time, know-how and resources to embark upon this journey?' However, it's often the non-practical questions that end up being the most pertinent ones: 'Do I have the drive and fortitude to finish what I started? Can I allow myself to be vulnerable in front of my children when I don't know the answers, when I need space, when we need to discuss awkward topics, when I need to teach issues of the heart that aren't prescribed in any textbook, yet are necessary for life and living? Am I aware of the pros and cons?'

In my experience, the benefits of homeschooling are many:

- It offers a tailor-made education, but not at private school prices.
- You'll also save on fees, uniforms, transport, school lunches, field trips and all the other things that add up.
- Children learning in their natural environments don't struggle

with the issue of being liked, being 'cool' and keeping up appearances.

- The time saved in commuting and other school activities has allowed many homeschoolers to discover other interests such as art, business, sport, etc.
- Your children will be able to move at their own pace, which manages the issues of being bored and feeling kept back, or overwhelmed and hurried along.
- The application of knowledge in real-life scenarios is much easier. Everywhere is the classroom and a news broadcast can be a social studies lesson.

'Staying informed and on top of homeschooling trends is vital for me. I research religiously and scour various publications.'

As a parent, you already are a teacher. You're the best-placed person to impart knowledge to your child. By virtue of the unique communication styles you adapt when dealing with each of your children, you can adapt to their individual learning styles as well, thereby taking half the struggle out of getting the message across.

On the downside:

- Complacency can set in because of the familiarity among family and in the home environment.
- The homeschooling environment could suffer from a lack of subject-specific expertise, especially in the areas of maths and the sciences. This can be addressed by recruiting tutors, which could add extra costs.

I admit there are times when I just want to sleep in or focus solely on domestic responsibilities or other issues. There are also times when I question myself. I may wonder whether I'm doing too much or too little. But those times are few and far between and the truth is that we all have those moments in life, whether at work, in relationships, in projects, parenting or teaching.

The fruit is what always justifies the process. So, if you're clear on what the desired output is – well-rounded, capable individuals with the ability to make it in the world, led by an insatiable desire to learn and improve – and you can honestly assess yourself and your children against that goal, then I'd say: embrace both roles, and the gaps and advantages of each one.

The right programme

Of course, one of the big questions is which homeschooling

system to follow and what to consider when selecting one.

In the early stages, I recommend the ACE curriculum. It's a brilliant system for learning to read, write and spell. It also lays down the fundamentals of maths in a very solid manner. However, as your children grow older, you'll need to figure out which vocational route they'd be likely to follow and, as such, which curriculum and its attending assessment are most likely to yield that outcome.

In my opinion, those aiming to go into fields like medicine, or study abroad, would benefit from the Cambridge curriculum. Bear in mind, though, that Cambridge is very particular in how assessment answers must be formulated and though many parents navigate their way through this, its structure may not suit every pupil.

We've also used the Love to Learn curriculum, which is a little pricey, but great for developing a love for reading and learning in general. Recently, we also started using Khan Academy to get plenty of practice in mental maths.

I allow a great deal of flexibility in the systems we use and I've had to change systems for my children from time to time. It might have had a negative cost implication, but that was once-off, as I have enough children to offset the costs



over time. The impact on time varies from child to child. For one child, it might be a change mid-topic and employing a curriculum that explains the topic better. For another, the introduction of an entirely new system might require repeating the whole grade.

Staying informed and on top of homeschooling trends is vital for me. I research religiously and scour various publications. I also get requests from time to time to review certain systems and tools, which exposes me regularly to those trends. I follow a few pages on social media and keep my ear to the ground about what's happening among parents and educators alike.

Socialising

Parents often worry that their children won't be properly socialised and able to integrate

into broader society (as they'd be prepared to do in traditional schools). Personally, having 10 individuals with different temperaments and personalities, I don't have that problem. I also think a lot of the emphasis placed on socialisation is over-rated. In fact, we've often found our children needing to unlearn some of the mannerisms, language and behaviours picked up in school.

But for those really worried about socialisation, this is where homeschooling communities come into play, offering a comfort blanket and a sounding board for those days of fear and uncertainty, and a chance for children to just hang out and play with others. And don't forget sports teams, matric events and socials, which are often grouped around your chosen curriculum or system.

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- Flexible learning allowing self-paced progression
- Digital mastery
- Flexible learning allowing self-paced progression
- An emphasis on the habits of mind and skills your child will need to thrive in a knowledge-based economy

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Raising a happy reader

In today's technology-driven world, reading to children has taken a back seat. It's easier to watch YouTube, a series or movie, or read a social media post, than to read a book. This trend has had a fundamental impact on your child's education, says remedial therapist **Marian Bailey**



Book-reading is time-consuming and sometimes even the best-intentioned parents don't enjoy reading,

so bedtime stories become a chore. Yet reading to your child from a young age is one of the best things you can do. Why? Because reading to your baby, toddler or young child helps prepare their brain to acquire reading skills and is the beginning of their reading journey.

But teaching a child to read isn't as simple or obvious as might be imagined. Reading doesn't come naturally to all children; in fact, most children need explicit reading



instruction. According to the Ladder of Reading by Nancy Young (www.nancyyoung.ca), only 5% of the population seems effortlessly able to learn to read.

In addition, there's a large body of research called the 'science of reading', which refers to the research that reading experts – especially cognitive scientists – have conducted on how we learn to read. The bottom line of this research is that children don't just become readers; they need to be explicitly taught how.

It's essential that a child is taught in all five components of reading instruction – phonological awareness (this includes words, syllables, rhymes and sounds), structured and systematic phonics instruction, fluency instruction, vocabulary instruction and comprehension instruction – using explicit instruction and multi-sensory teaching methods. 'Explicit instruction' refers to teaching a child to read so well that they learn well. Using the method of 'I do it, we do it together, you do it on your own' is an effective method of explicit instruction. In other words, model what you're teaching in concise, clear language and

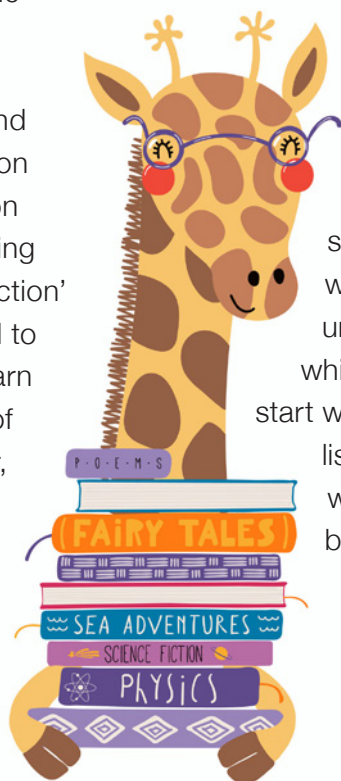


give your child an opportunity to interact with the concept using multi-sensory tools to build a strong memory of the concept. These tools are visual, auditory (hearing) and kinaesthetic (through touch).



then learn how we represent that sound and read it.

What's the connection between speech and acquiring reading skills? Sounds came first (language); then we developed letters to represent sound. In English there are 26 letters and 44 sounds. For a child to progress in phonics, he or she needs to be aware that sounds exist in the first place.



Think on this: the human brain is wired to communicate and speak, but we're not wired to read. We can understand language, which is why we start with the sounds. By listening to the sound, we're tuning a child's brain to be ready to

'The human brain is wired to communicate and speak, but we're not wired to read.'



Where do I even start?

Begin early by playing with sounds (rhyming and alliteration), playing with words and clapping syllables. Talk to your children; encourage conversations and complete sentences because oral language is the base, before it translates into print. Make reading a part of your family's life, be a good reading role model, develop the reading habit early and fit reading in – it doesn't always have to happen at bedtime; anytime reading builds reading habits. Continue reading stories to your children even when they start learning to read and can read beginner books. There's a difference between a child's reading age and listening age. Your child still needs to be read to by a fluent reader to be exposed to good language and vocabulary,

story structure and character development. Above all, read to your child in an interactive way to develop language.

Sometimes the reading journey seems overwhelming and you might worry that you won't get it right. But please know you're not alone. Help is at hand. Raising Readers is excited to be bringing you regular articles in *SAH*, covering and breaking down the five components of reading, how to do explicit reading instruction and multi-sensory teaching, as well as the power of teaching sight words using the heart method.

Learning to read is a long, yet deeply rewarding adventure. Try not to rush your child; rather build solid foundations and enjoy the ride as the miracle of learning unfolds. ■

What reading does

- Readers have many advantages over non-readers because reading underpins all learning.
- A child who is read to from a young age – and who reads easily – benefits both cognitively and emotionally.
- A regular reader has a way to access information and develops a wider vocabulary and general knowledge.
- It can improve spelling.
- A regular reader develops a rich imagination, learns empathy and patience, and acquires self-knowledge.
- Being read to – or reading a book on their own if they're older – can be a way to decompress, a time to forget about stresses and worries and enter that fantastical world of adventure, dragons, lions, forests and heroes.



All about Alpha

Alpha Education SA's staff have been involved with the homeschooling and distance learning community since 2006 and have learnt much about the needs, frustrations and triumphs of the students and parents who choose to educate from home.

Our organisation has much experience in dealing with the limited curriculum-providers in South Africa and has first-hand experience of the pitfalls and

challenges these organisations face. Over the years, we have learnt how we can make the homeschooling experience more successful and rewarding.

Alpha Education SA has studied the system of learning many students use and has identified its shortfalls. This has led to the development of its unique A+ Study Program, which teaches the 'self-study' method of learning. This is a technique that will be required once the student moves on to university, diploma and certificate

courses, other post-school courses or technical college. Our courses incorporate this program, helping develop a sense of responsibility, accountability, self-discipline and – last, but not least – better memory skills. Students who have used the program have improved their results in leaps and bounds. Although it is highly successful among senior students, it is simple enough for a pupil as young as Grade 4 to follow and master. Remedial students who have used it have even moved on to technical colleges and earned straight As.

Contact details: For more detailed information on our courses, please visit: www.alphaedsa.co.za

Tel: (016) 018-0069 – Head Office (for queries regarding customer care, enrolment and support, production and dispatch)

Email: customercare@alphaedsa.co.za (academic information) or enquiries@alphaedsa.co.za (enrolment and support)



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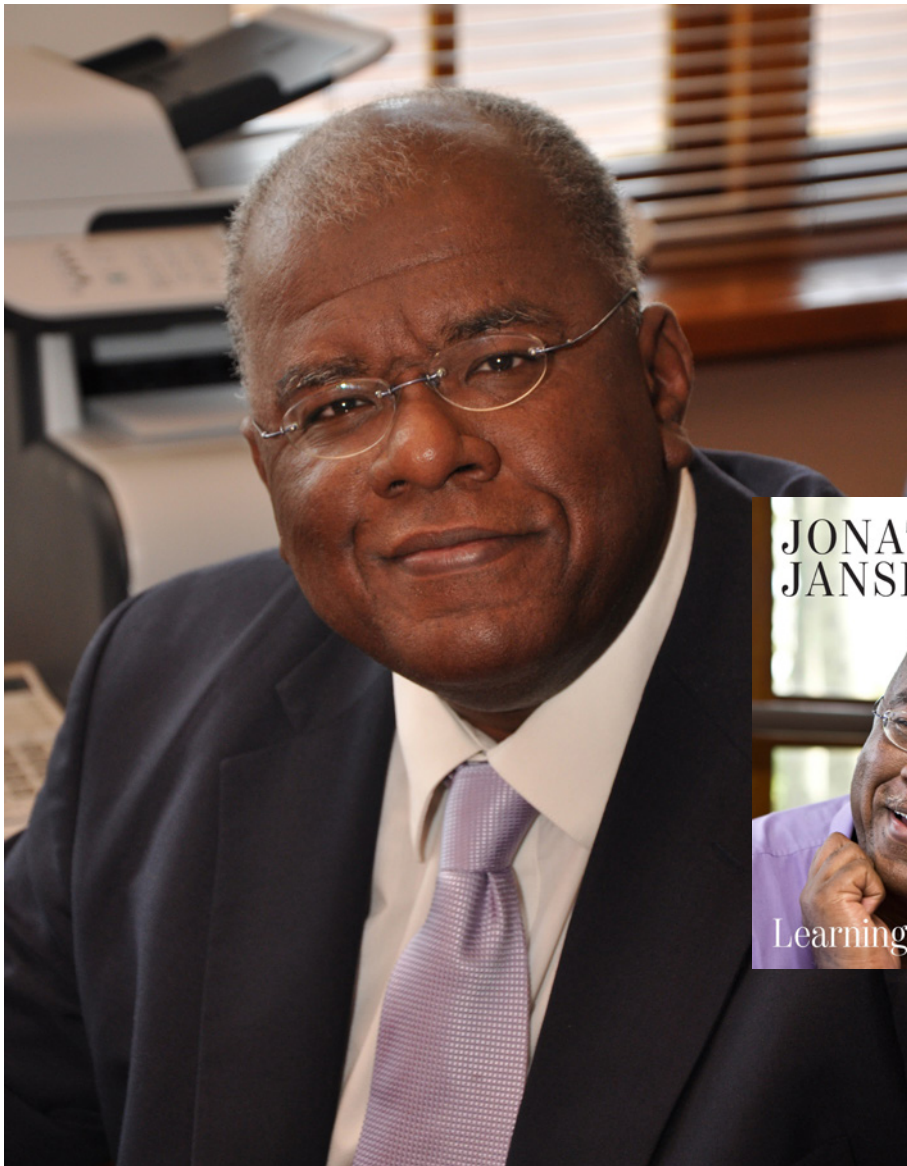
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Teach your children well

SAH asked some probing questions of educator, writer and critical thinker Prof Jonathan Jansen. His answers provide much food for thought, while highlighting the importance of finding the right subject matter tutors and teachers



JONATHAN JANSSEN

Learning Lessons

S **AH:** Learning under lockdown has taught many parents that they themselves have much to learn about facilitating learning. What are the top three skills homeschooling parents need to develop in themselves?

JJ: Knowledge of the subject (content), knowledge of how to teach (pedagogy) and knowledge of student learning (cognition). Anyone can transfer information with varying degrees of efficiency so that children pass examinations, but few can teach deeply and broadly in an intellectually honest way. This requires years of training and development before and during teaching.

What might homeschooled children lack compared with traditionally schooled children?

It depends on the design of the homeschooling experience and the motivation of particular parents. Where parents want to withdraw their children from public education for fear of racial mixing

or state indoctrination, they do lasting damage to their children's capacity for learning the habits of democracy, social inclusion and intellectual agility. Where parents withdraw their children because they believe they can do a better job (without advanced teaching qualifications), they risk under-teaching their children, with long-term consequences for their learning.

What is the essence of joyful learning?

Discovery. The ability to find the answers for yourself – under good facilitation, of course. The learnt

ability to be comfortable with uncertainty. Learning together with others. Learning to learn.

'I understood the power of teaching to change lives forever.'

What inspired you to become an educator?

The nudge came from my outstanding Latin teacher in junior high school (read my book, *Learning Lessons*, for the whole story). Then it was my experience of teaching on Day 1. My initial agenda was to pay back my bursary and then move on,

but I was hooked. I understood the power of teaching to change lives forever. I hope I've done that.

What is your hope for the future of basic education in South Africa – both in traditional and homeschools – and how can parents work towards that future?

My hope is that we lay strong and equitable foundations of early learning even before Grade 1, in ways that close the inequality gap in learner attainments by the start of school, and that we carry that through the system, including post-school education.

Prof Jansen is one of our most prolific writers, having brought out two books this year. Both will inspire you as you continue your journey of teaching and learning.

Learning Lessons (Bookstorm)

'Jonathan Jansen doesn't regard the achievements he's made in academia and his contributions to public intellectual life as his own. Rather, he sees these accomplishments as a product of the hard work and sacrifices of family, friends, teachers, colleagues and mentors around him.'

'Jansen recounts, in his inimitable way, how the people in his life invested love, direction, encouragement (and even money)

to make his journey possible – in the hope that his story might give inspiration and direction to generations of young people taking their first steps in adult life.'

Learning Under Lockdown (CNA), compiled by Jonathan Jansen and Emily O'Ryan

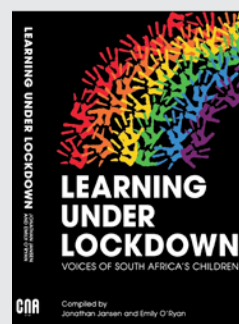
'*Learning Under Lockdown* is a collection of about 400 essays selected from 640 submissions from pupils around the country. Renowned educator, Prof Jonathan Jansen and Fulbright Scholarship winner Emily O'Ryan of Stellenbosch University, compiled the book

when they realised that – worldwide – no-one was asking pupils how they were coping in this extraordinary time.

'Faced with fear of the

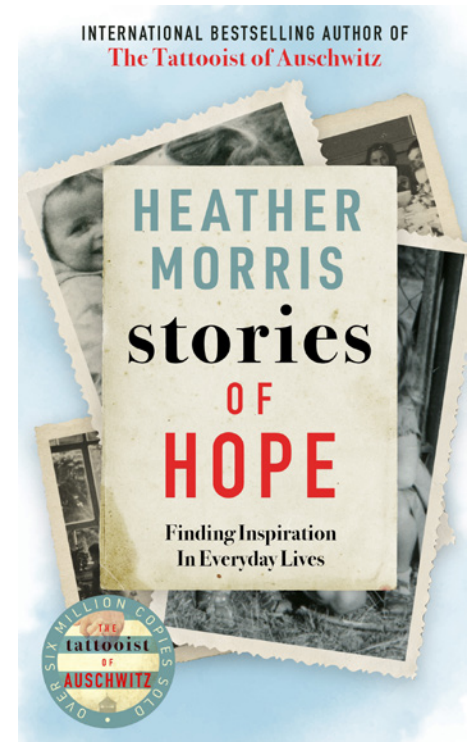
unknown – as well as isolation from peers and teachers, cancelled extramural activities and disappointment about lost milestones of the school year (the matric dance, in particular) – almost all the pupils nevertheless write

of their determination to keep being educated. Their essays reveal something unshakably positive about them: the depth of their resilience, patience and perseverance.'



Calling all readers!

Enjoy a delicious selection of books for reading aloud and reading alone – from the daredevil doings of *Kaptein PipSkwiek* to the urgent wisdom of David Attenborough



S **stories of Hope: Finding Inspiration in Everyday Lives by Heather Morris (Manilla Press)**

The world-renowned author of *The Tattooist of Auschwitz* and *Cilka's Journey* now shares this absolute treasure of personal stories gathered along her own journey. Reading it is like listening to a kind and thoughtful friend who wants you to live your best life.

Enjoy this short extract:

It doesn't matter how close or intimate we may be with someone, even our nearest and dearest won't know 100% of the time what headspace we're in, or even what's happened to us in the preceding minutes, hours or days. For we may not have communicated it to them in such a way that they were able to hear.

It all comes down to the first few words we say when we want someone to listen. Not to advise – just to listen. I've learnt that the words 'Can I tell you something?' are the best way to get attention. Maybe the other person thinks I'm going to tell them a secret, but it works for me. Of course, time and place are a major factor when needing someone to truly listen to you, but equally, it's essential to ask to be heard. What follows are the basic elements of listening, as I understand them – again, I write not as an expert, but rather from experience – as a parent, a partner, a sibling, a social worker and, more recently, as a writer.

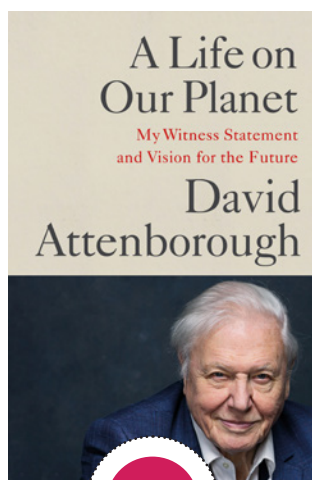
Active listening

This sounds odd, doesn't it? How do you not listen actively? Well, the short answer is that it's not as easy or as obvious as it sounds. This is not, in my opinion, the

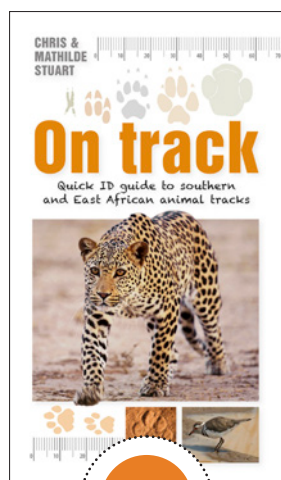
listening we do all the time, every time we're in conversation with someone. But the basic ideas and techniques of active listening can be learnt and practised, and they'll make us all better listeners.

The key idea behind active listening is to focus concentration entirely on the speaker, to give them the space and encouragement to tell you what they want you to hear. This is a different transaction from the phatic communication I was talking about earlier in this chapter, where you and the neighbour exchange 'hello's' and chat about your weekends – there, the aim is simply positive communication.

The basic rules of active listening are: to concentrate, to understand, to respond, to remember what's being said and to withhold judgements or opinions.



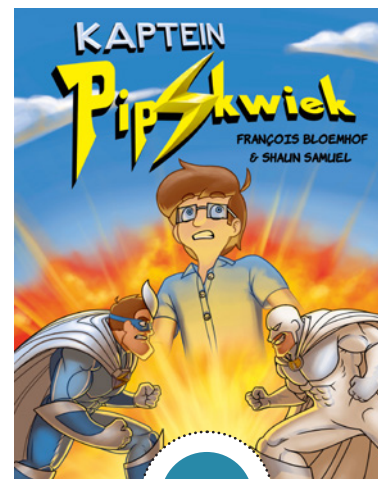
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2



3



4

1. *A Life on Our Planet: My Witness Statement and a Vision for the Future* by David Attenborough (Witness Books)

If you missed the glorious film of the same name on Netflix, fear not. *A Life on our Planet* doesn't pull any punches, but international hero Attenborough offers real hope and solutions for the future of our planet and those who dwell on her – if we just make a little more effort. While very much a grown-up read, it's rich with marvellous anecdotes, photos, illustrations and talking points for the whole family.

2. *On Track* by Chris and Mathilde Stuart (Struik)

Subtitled the *Quick ID guide to Southern and East African Animal*

Tracks, this little gem covers our more common mammals, reptiles and birds and can be used by eager young trackers country-wide, whether they're country kids or city-dwellers. Parents are also likely to get hooked, so dig out that magnifying glass and get tracking.

3. *Manage Your Money Like a Grownup: The Best Money Advice for Teens* by Sam Beckbessinger (Jonathan Ball)

And speaking of grown-ups, Sam Beckbessinger's latest offering will inspire not only the youth, but also the not-so-young to get a better handle on their finances. It's absolutely packed with tips, how-to's and insights and belongs on every family's bookshelf. An easy, yet essential read.

4. *Kaptein PipSkwiek* by François Bloemhof and Shaun Samuel (Struik Kinders)

Graphic novels are not only huge fun, they're the secret door that takes reluctant readers into the world of books and learning. This one is ideal for adventurous boys and girls who like wit and action, and would be excellent for encouraging Afrikaans second-language learners to have fun while learning the *taal*.

All books are available at selected CNA stores and most online and local bookstores. Prices vary according to where you shop. Happy reading!



CHAT TO US!

SA homeschoolers, we'd love to know what you think of your launch issue and what more you'd like to read in future issues.

Your **feedback is essential** in helping us put together a magazine which delivers on-point content relevant to your homeschooling experiences and support needs and **helps you navigate** your child/children's education with ease and confidence.

You are the **core** of the publication, so let's live and learn together. **Email our editor**, Shelagh Foster, at: shelagh@isikhova.co.za.

Spring into summer!

Forget those books and online lessons for a bit and let your hair down while you replenish your energy resources with fun activities and a family-friendly meal

1

HIIT the dancefloor

High-Intensity Interval Training (HIIT) involves alternate bursts of intense activity with short cooling-down periods – but why not make it a whole lot more fun by creating your own 10- or 15-minute playlist of family favourite tunes? All you need to do is dance like crazy for 40 seconds, slow down for 20 seconds and repeat until the blood is pumping and your children are rolling on the floor laughing at your moves!

2

Step out

Families who walk together talk together, so dust off those cobwebs and make it a daily family habit, come rain or shine.



3

This is the way we sweep the floor...

Teaching your children to help with housework can be an uphill battle, so get silly and add a sing-along to chore time. Your neighbours may think you're all nuts, but who cares!?

4

Healthy minds

Meditation might not be everyone's cup of chamomile, but experts agree that it has many benefits, including helping children process information more clearly. We love the www.stopbreathethink.com/kids app, developed in collaboration with Susan Kaiser Greenland, author of *Mindful Games* and internationally recognised leader in teaching mindfulness and meditation to families.

**What to do**

1. Layer the corn chips on a large baking tray or roasting pan.
2. Drain the red kidney beans into a saucepan and simmer, together with the tomatoes, for 10 minutes, or until the beans start becoming mushy and the mixture has thickened a little.
3. Immediately spoon the bean and tomato mixture onto the corn chips, then dot the cottage cheese over it, followed by the grated cheese.
4. Pop under the grill for 10 minutes, or until the cheese starts to bubble.
5. Meanwhile, mash or blend the avocados with the lemon juice, cumin, coriander powder, fresh coriander, salt and pepper. If you like, stir in half a finely chopped red onion and/or a few finely chopped cherry tomatoes (they don't become as mushy as large tomatoes), as well as a teaspoon of chopped mild chilli.
6. Serve the nachos straight from the baking tray, with a big dollop of guacamole on the side.

5

Happy tummies

(Serves four)

This nachos and quacamole supper is so easy-peasy that your children will be able to help with much of the prep.

What you'll need

1 x 410g can red kidney beans
 1 x 410g can Mexican-style tomatoes (or Italian-style, if you're not keen on chilli)
 1 large packet corn chips (we love Santa Anna and Bandito's)
 1 x 250g tub cream cheese or smooth cottage cheese
 250g (1 cup) grated cheese (2 cups, if you're super-cheesy)
 2 medium ripe avocados
 Approximately 20ml (4 tsp) lemon juice
 ¼ tsp cumin powder (optional)
 ¼ tsp coriander powder (optional)
 Salt and black pepper to taste
 Handful of fresh chopped coriander



New ADvTECH school offering set to revolutionise online education

Opening its virtual doors to learners from Grade R to Grade 9, from January 2021, ADvTECH's new online offering, Evolve Online School (Evolve), will change the face of online schooling in South Africa.

'In this rapidly changing society, the one-size-fits-all method of teaching no longer makes any sense,' says principal Colin Northmore. 'Evolve starts by answering the question: how can we make learning an adventure for each child?'

Evolve combines a user-experience focus with a trendsetting curriculum mapping system, developed at MIT, to personalise each child's learning experience. Using the latest research, each child's learning journey will be designed based on exclusive subject and skill maps.

Students will be placed within subjects according to their abilities, letting them progress faster where they're gifted and work at a more deliberate pace to master content they find more challenging. The result is that each student's learning experience is tailored to their specific needs and they're encouraged to grow at a pace that suits their ability and enthusiasm.

'There'll be a strong focus on foundational, social and emotional learning skills. Our team of life coaches will focus exclusively on these skills. Our children are growing up in a world very different from the one in which



we grew up. Things that we, as adults, deal with and take in our stride, they're already facing at a very young age. Our life coaches will play a very important role in teaching students how to deal with issues such as stress and anxiety, and help them develop coping mechanisms, resilience and a growth mindset,' adds Northmore.

Evolve will make use of the following:

- **Diagnostic testing** to determine the exact level of proficiency of a student before

placement and during the educational journey.

- **Asynchronous learning** so that learners can move through content at their own pace and according to their own proficiency. Students will also have direct access to their teachers, who'll facilitate extra activation classes.
- **Synchronous learning**, where our students will also be able to attend live interactive classes, making this a true online school.
- **Socialisation opportunities** with academies, studios and day camps monthly so that students can meet other 'Evolvers' and get green time to balance their screen time.

Now enrolling for 2021.

The school will cater for Grades R-9 from January 2021. Grades 10-12 will be phased in from 2022. ADvTECH is Africa's largest private education provider. Its schools division includes iconic brands such as Crawford Schools, Trinityhouse and Abbotts.

Visit: www.evolveonline.co.za for more information or email: info@evolveonline.co.za.



To which degree?

One day, your teen will fly the nest to start life's big adventure. But to study what, why and where? Let them read this . . .

Mandela Rhodes Scholar and co-author of *Your First Year of Varsity: A Survival Guide for College and University*, Lehlohonolo Mofokeng, offers the following tips for pupils aiming to study further.

First, the don'ts:

- You might be desperate to get into a university, but avoid applying for a bursary for a degree you're not passionate about. Studying something you don't care about will leave you miserable.
- Don't choose the degree based on what your parents think best suits you. This is *your* future.
- Don't choose a degree just because you think it will make you quick money.
- Don't choose a degree you haven't thoroughly researched.
- Don't choose a degree with a low employability rate.

Rather ensure that the course you choose is in your chosen field of study and matches your personality. If you're unsure, career counselling can open your eyes to available opportunities. Most campuses offer this at no charge.

Once you've narrowed your choices, make sure you know what the entry requirements are. Then look at various institutions and decide which one best suits your field.

If your parents are paying, know how much they've saved for your education and whether this will be enough to complete your qualification. If you need to fund – or supplement – your own studies, carefully consider all the financial options available. Work out how you'll pay for fees, textbooks and other costs for each year. If you'll need to work part-time to augment your finances, start researching which companies or shops hire students in that vicinity.

The location of your chosen institution is also important. Will it involve extensive travelling and, if so, will you be able to board in the residence or seek lodgings near the campus? Do you have any friends also hoping to study there who could possibly share such lodgings with you? How many times will you be able to come home each year? Do you have any family members in that area?

Some tertiary institutions are better than others in certain fields of study, so do your homework before making a final decision. Find the answers to the following questions:



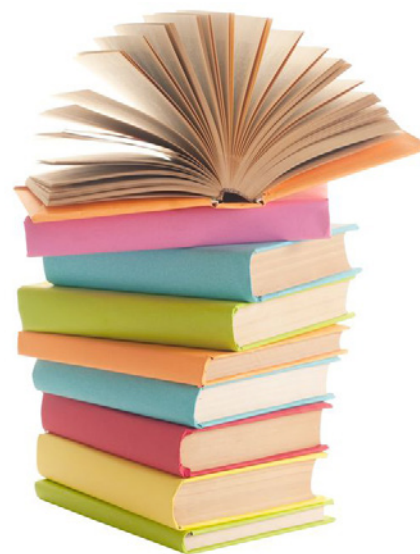
- Is your qualification technical (such as engineering)? If so, is a university of technology, a college or a traditional university your best option?
- How often do companies in your chosen field hold career exhibitions at your preferred place of study? (This will indicate how long you're likely to wait before you're employed after graduating!)
- How many professors and other academics in this institution are internationally recognised in your field of interest?

Choose an institution that has your well-being at heart; you don't want to be somewhere that only cares about your money. Ask friends of friends of friends.

Lastly, look at the success rate of both the under-graduate and post-graduate students. At tertiary

level, there are universities that are research-intensive and those whose primary focus is teaching. Research-intensive universities often don't hold teaching in high regard and lectures are handled by their post-graduate students. If you research this beforehand, you can choose a university where you'll receive the best tuition by experienced lecturers.

Good luck!



Wall of Wisdom



'If you are, you breathe.

If you breathe, you talk.

If you talk, you ask.

If you ask, you think.

If you think, you search.

If you search, you experience.

If you experience, you learn.

If you learn, you grow.

If you grow, you wish.

If you wish, you find.

And if you find, you doubt.

If you doubt, you question.

If you question, you understand
and if you understand, you know.

If you know, you want to know
more. If you want to know more,
you are alive.'

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SA Homeschooling Magazine is your go-to source and survival guide for homeschooling and aims to provide you with all the support, resources, skills and expert advice to homeschool your children successfully and with ease.

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